

# ASIA, HISTORY OF



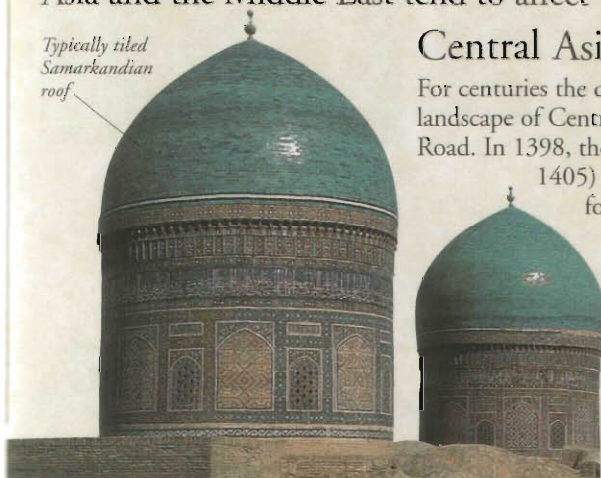
ASIA IS THE WORLD'S LARGEST continent and the birthplace of the world's earliest civilizations, such as those of the Sumerians, China, and India. The emergence of these civilizations had a profound impact on history, both ancient and modern, as did the emergence of three major world religions: Hinduism, Buddhism, and Islam. Colonial interference affected Asia's development over the centuries, but after decades of independent growth, today's Asian economies are booming. There are still conflicts, however, and those in Southeast Asia and the Middle East tend to affect world politics.



## Early development

Early civilizations in Asia were largely isolated from each other and from the rest of the world by barriers of deserts, mountains, and oceans. Only the Middle East had strong connections with Europe. Therefore, Asian civilizations and cultures developed independently for thousands of years. Over time, major civilizations, such as those of India and China, began to affect other Asian countries.

Typically tiled Samarkandian roof



## Central Asia

For centuries the only travellers in the inhospitable landscape of Central Asia were traders using the Silk Road. In 1398, the Mongolian warrior Timur (1336–1405) swept down from the steppes and founded a Central Asian empire.

### Samarkand

In 1369, Timur moved his capital to the prosperous city of Samarkand, in modern Uzbekistan. The city experienced a golden age and became the architectural jewel of Central Asia as Timur and his descendants built palaces, astronomical observatories, and Islamic colleges. In the early 1500s, nomadic Uzbeks attacked the city.

Uleg Beg Medrasa, Uzbekistan



Swat, Pakistan

## Kushan Empire

In c.170 BC, a northern Chinese clan, the Yuezhi, moved west to Central Asia. By the 3rd century AD, they had founded an empire that stretched from eastern Iran to the Ganges in India. The Kushans controlled fertile river valleys and were at the centre of the silk trade. They encouraged Buddhism and religious art, but declined in the 4th century.

## Padmasambhava

A legendary sage and yoga expert from Swat, modern Pakistan, Padmasambhava founded Tibetan Buddhism. He and his consort, Yeshe Tsogyal, arrived in Tibet in 747, and established the first Buddhist monastery. The sage then spent his life writing and lecturing on the religion.



Semi-precious stones

## Ancient civilizations

The Sumerians of western Asia evolved the world's first civilization, but it was the early civilizations of India and China that affected Asia the most. Their religions had special impact: Hinduism (the religion of the people of India) and Buddhism (founded by Siddhartha Gautama and one of the three great religions of China) spread over Asia.



Koguryo openwork cup

## Koguryo dynasty

By the 7th century China's influence was increasing, and Chinese monks converted Korea to Buddhism. The Koguryo rulers (1st century BC–AD 7th century) encouraged the spread of Buddhism. From Korea, the missionaries went to Japan, which adopted not only Buddhism but also Chinese script, architecture, and culture.

## Chola dynasty

From 850–c.1200, a powerful dynasty known as the Cholas began to dominate much of India. They built many Hindu temples and spread their religion to Sri Lanka. They extended their naval power over the seas of Southeast Asia, and this helped spread Hinduism as far as Sumatra and Bali.

## Southeast Asia

For 1,000 years, India was the major shaping force of this region, and provided a mould for Southeast Asian culture, art, and religion. Its influence declined after c.1300.

### Sea routes

From c.300, Indian traders sailed to Thailand, Malaysia, Indonesia, and the Philippines. From the 1200s, Arabian merchants spread Islam along sea trade routes. From c.1500, the region also traded with Europe.

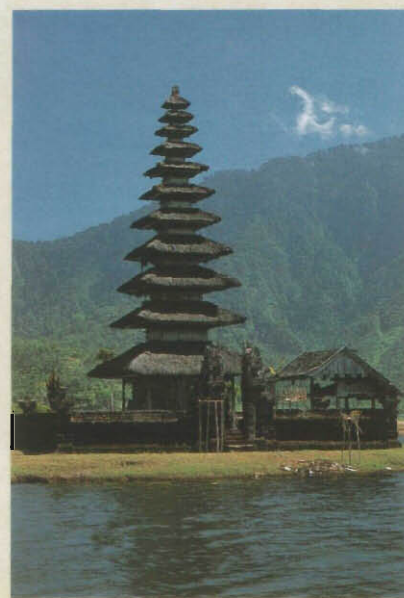
Dhow leaving Muscat, Oman



### Siam

Over centuries, waves of migrants from the north entered Siam (Thailand), and intermarried with the native tribes. In the 13th century, one tribe, the Thais, unified Siam into a single nation with one monarch and one religion – Buddhism.

Thai tribal woman



A Hindu temple in Bali, Indonesia, attests to the great influence of the Chola dynasty.